TRAINING CONTRACT 2027 CYCLE

Cracking the Law Firm Online Assessment

Situational judgement, critical thinking and job simulations, explained from zero, with Macfarlanes as the worked example.

What it is | How it's marked | The mindset | Step-by-step

Prepared October 2026. Provider details change between cycles: always confirm on the firm's own careers page.

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The 60-second version

01

If you read nothing else, read this page

An online assessment is a set of computer-based tests that law firms use to decide who gets an interview. You do it at home, in your own time, usually within a deadline (Macfarlanes gives **seven days**). It is not a law exam: **no legal knowledge is needed**. It tests how you would behave as a trainee and how clearly you think.

What it tests	How it's marked	The winning mindset	The trap
How you'd act at work (judgement) and how logically you reason	Your answers are compared to the firm's 'ideal trainee' answer key	Client first, say yes and make it work, own it, love learning	'Most proactive = best' is only mostly true. Over-committing and ignoring clues lose marks

★ **The five rules that pass most situational questions**

- **The client's need beats your comfort.** Clarity, deadlines and trust come first.
- **Say yes, then make it work.** Reprioritise and tell people. Never just refuse.
- **Take ownership when it's offered.** If a supervisor invites you to lead, lead.
- **Be hungry to learn, but realistic.** Enthusiasm plus a plan, never 'I'll try my best'.
- **Read the scenario for clues.** It usually tells you what the firm values in that moment.

⚑ **And the critical thinking golden rule**

Treat the passage as 100% true, use **zero outside knowledge**, and only say a conclusion follows if the passage **proves** it. 'Probably' and 'makes sense' are not proof.

What the assessment is

02

Who it's for, why firms use it, what it looks like

Who sits it?

Anyone applying for a **vacation scheme** (a paid 1 to 3 week work experience placement) or a **training contract** (the two-year paid job that turns you into a qualified solicitor) at most large UK law firms. Everyone sits the same test, whatever their background:

Law students	Non-law students	Graduates	Career changers
Usually in 2nd (penultimate) or final year	Any degree. Same test, no disadvantage	Already finished university	Paralegals, other professions

> **i Assumption you need to know**
>
> Since the SQE (Solicitors Qualifying Exam) replaced the old LPC route, law and non-law applicants compete on an equal footing. The online assessment therefore tests **potential and behaviour**, not legal knowledge. Some firms (including Macfarlanes) now call the training contract a 'training programme'. Same thing.

Why do firms use it?

Reason	What it means for you
Volume	Top firms get thousands of applications for 20 to 30 places. Tests filter fairly and fast.
Fairness	Many stages are 'application-blind': the scorer doesn't see your university or grades. A strong test can lift a less polished CV.
Prediction	Situational tests predict how you'd actually behave as a trainee better than a CV does.
A preview	Scenarios are built from real trainee life (seats, supervisors, clients). It shows you the job, and checks you'd enjoy it.

The question types you'll meet

Type	What you do	What it measures
Ranking (SJT)	Order 4 to 5 responses from most to least likely / effective	Judgement, priorities, values
'How do you feel?'	Rank or pick the response closest to how you'd feel	Motivation, resilience, enthusiasm
Slider / rating	Place yourself on a scale between two statements	Strengths and preferences
Critical thinking	Decide if conclusions follow / assumptions are made / arguments are strong	Logic, reading precision
Job simulation tasks	Handle emails, prioritise, review documents, sometimes short video or written answers	Doing the actual job

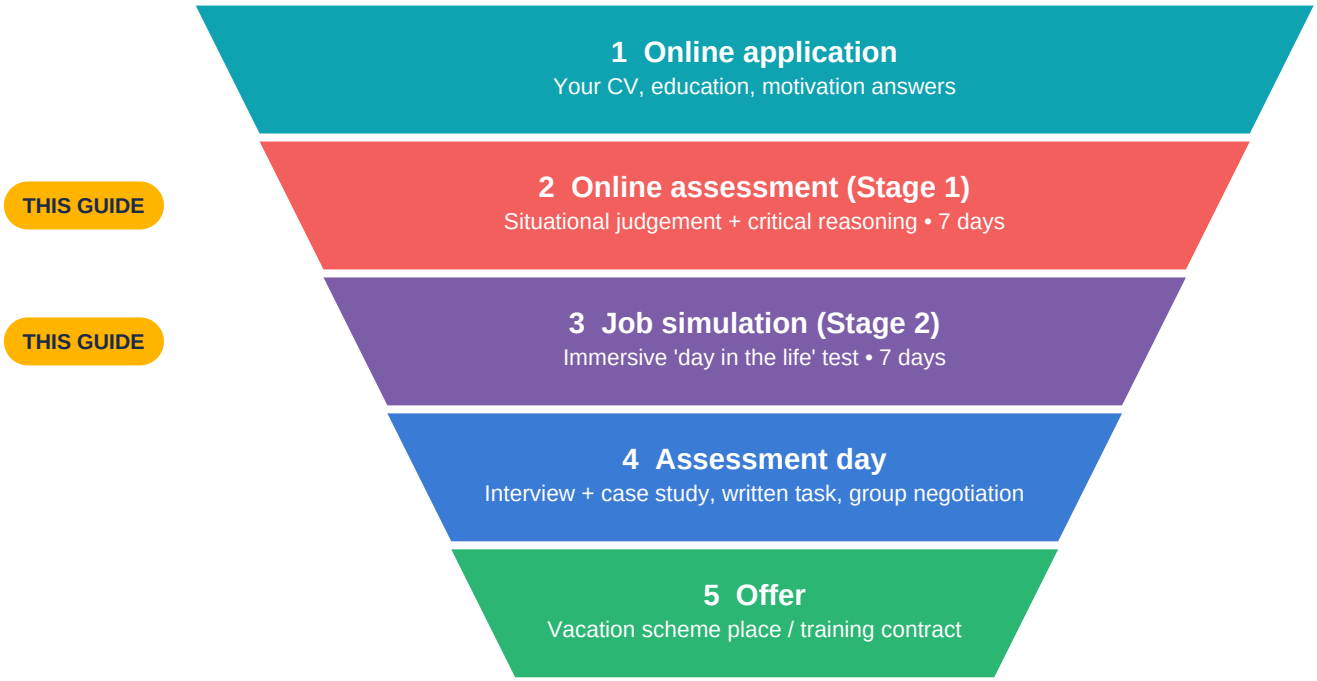
The process and the platform

Where the test sits, and who builds it

03

The Macfarlanes funnel

Here is the full Macfarlanes route, from the firm's own careers pages. Most City firms follow a similar shape. The two stages in this guide are tagged.



Important: Macfarlanes says Stage 1 answers are considered **alongside your written application**. So the test isn't a pure pass/fail gate. A great score helps carry a weaker application and vice versa, but a poor score is very hard to recover from.

The platform: Cappfinity

Macfarlanes' tests are built by **Cappfinity** (sometimes written 'Capp'), a UK assessment company. The firm recommends candidates use the **Cappfinity preparation hub** before sitting either stage. Things to know about Cappfinity tests:

- **Strengths-based.** It looks at what you enjoy and are energised by, not just what you can do. That is why so many options say 'you love...' or 'you enjoy...'.
- **Immersive.** You follow one storyline as a trainee moving through seats (Corporate, Finance, Private Client, Litigation), with emails, chats and videos from colleagues.
- **Mixed formats.** Ranking, single choice, sliders and reasoning questions appear in the same flow.
- **Response behaviour may be recorded.** Prep providers report that Cappfinity tracks how long you take. Not officially confirmed, but the safe approach is steady and decisive: don't rush, don't agonise for ten minutes on one item.
- **Commit on sliders.** Candidates widely report that sitting in the middle of a slider scores worse than taking a clear side.

Does it differ between firms?

Yes. The **platform** differs and the **answer key** differs, because each firm calibrates the key to its own culture. But the underlying ideal trainee is remarkably similar everywhere.

Provider	What it feels like	Firms reported using it*
Cappfinity	Immersive storyline, strengths-based SJT, sliders, reasoning	Macfarlanes (confirmed), Ashurst, Osborne Clarke
Watson Glaser (Pearson)	Pure critical thinking: 5 sections, ~40 questions, ~30 minutes, strictly timed	Widely used by City and US firms, e.g. Addleshaw Goddard, Cleary Gottlieb, Milbank

Provider	What it feels like	Firms reported using it*
Amberjack	Realistic scenario SJT, feedback by 'pillars'	Various mid-size and City firms
SHL / Sova / Arctic Shores	Classic SJTs, verbal tests, or game-based personality tasks	Various
Video interview (e.g. HireVue)	Record answers to questions on camera	Some firms add this after the tests

* From candidate forums and prep sites. Firms switch providers between cycles, so check each firm's careers page before you prepare.

✓ **What stays the same across every firm**

- Client focus, teamwork, ownership, resilience, appetite to learn.
- Watson Glaser logic rules (Section 7) apply to every critical thinking test.
- What changes: the tone (e.g. how much a firm values independence vs checking in), so read each firm's values page and scenario clues.

How it's marked

04

The benchmark you're being compared against

Firms and providers don't publish exact marking schemes. Below is what is known and what is consistently reported. The labels tell you which is which.

Situational judgement: the answer key

- **There is a key.** For each question the firm agrees an 'ideal' ranking, typically calibrated on how its strong trainees and associates answer, plus the firm's values. **[widely reported]**
- **Closeness counts.** Rankings are commonly scored by distance from the key: exact positions score most, one place out still earns something, and swapping best and worst loses the most. **[reported, not officially confirmed]**
- **The extremes matter most.** Getting #1 and #5 right protects most of your marks. Middle options are often close, so don't panic over 2 vs 3.
- **Consistency is checked.** Similar ideas appear several times. Answering as one consistent person matters more than 'gaming' each item.

Illustration: how a ranking can be scored against the firm's key

	Rank 1	Rank 2	Rank 3	Rank 4	Rank 5
Firm's key	C	A	D	E	B
Your answer	C	D	A	E	B

Exact match = full credit One place out = partial credit (reported, not confirmed) Best/worst swapped = biggest loss

Critical thinking: right or wrong

Each reasoning item has one correct answer. There's no partial credit and no negative marking reported, so **never leave anything blank**.

The cut-off: you're compared to other candidates

There is usually no fixed pass mark. Your result is compared with a **norm group** (other applicants or a benchmark population), and the firm sets a threshold depending on how many people it can interview. That's why 'good' is not enough in a competitive year: you need to be clearly above the pack.

♦ **What a Macfarlanes reviewer effectively sees**

Input	Weight in the decision
Stage 1 SJT + critical reasoning score	Read alongside your application (firm's own wording)
Written application	Motivation for the firm, experience, academics
Stage 2 job simulation	Decides who reaches the assessment day

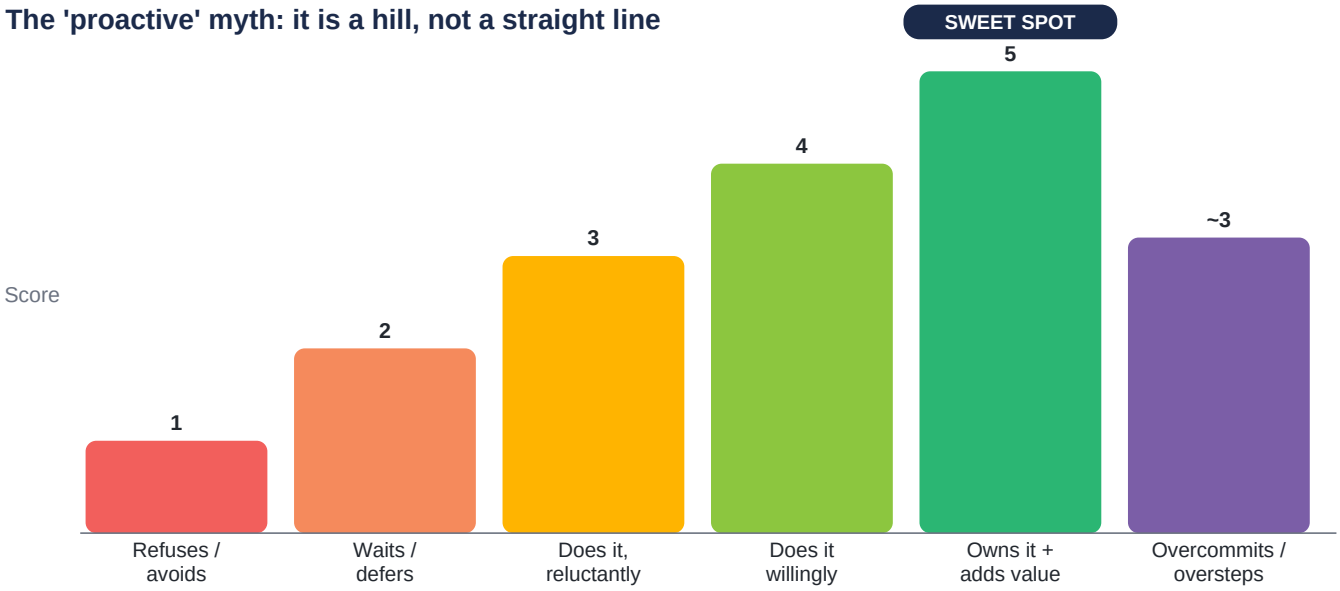
The winning mindset

Beyond 'rank the most proactive first'

05

The popular advice is 'rank from most proactive to least proactive'. It's a good start and will get most questions roughly right. But the people who **top** the test think one level deeper: **'Which response produces the best outcome for the client and the team, while showing I take responsibility and want to grow?'**

The 'proactive' myth: it is a hill, not a straight line

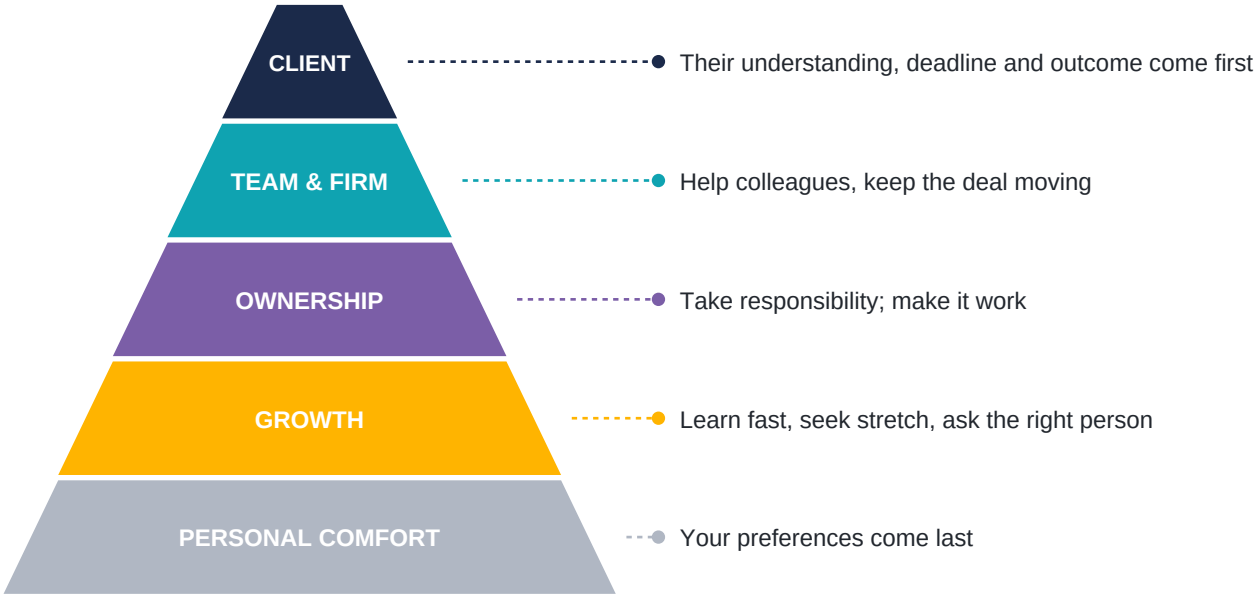


Look at the right-hand bar. **Over-proactive answers lose marks.** Real examples from the Macfarlanes practice set:

- **Optional workshops (Q4):** 'Re-organise your diary to attend *all* workshops and do all your client work' ranks only 4th. Signing up for the *most useful* ones ranks 1st. Balance beats burnout.
- **Agenda changes on the day (Q13):** grabbing a more knowledgeable colleague sounds resourceful, but ranks 4th. Adapting and preparing yourself ranks 1st.
- **Lynette asks you to do the analysis (Q9):** agreeing, then handing the core work to someone else, ranks last. Ownership means doing it.

The Trainee Compass: who comes first

When two good options compete, use this order of priority:



Eight mindset rules, with the evidence

Mindset	Looks like	Practice example
1. Client first	Make it understandable, meet the deadline, build trust	Q6 and Q14: simplify complex content for the client, even when it costs you time
2. Yes, and here's how	Agree, then reprioritise and communicate	Q7: cover the ill colleague and replan your own work (1st); 'no capacity' (last)
3. Own it	Volunteer for specific tasks; accept accountability	Q3: take ownership of several tasks (1st); 'only if I have to' (last)
4. Love learning	Enjoy steep learning curves; seek stretch	Q2 and Q15: 'I love learning / the most challenging tasks' rank 1st
5. Resourceful, not helpless	Find the right expert quickly, don't sit stuck	Q8: find another senior colleague (1st); struggle alone (last)
6. Independent when trusted	If told 'it's up to you', decide yourself	Q12: Emma left the approach open, so asking her where to start ranks last
7. Confident, not arrogant	Accept the spotlight; tailor to the audience	Q10: present, emphasising credibility for a formal client (1st)
8. Balanced, not reckless	Prioritise; don't promise everything	Q4: pick the most beneficial workshops, not all of them

☞ **Read the clue the scenario gives you**

The question text very often hands you the answer. Underline these phrases mentally:

- 'Hard work and flexibility are required' → reward the flexible, can-do option.
- 'She is open as to how you approach it' → reward independence, punish asking.
- 'Prefers strictly formal business conduct' → reward credibility and professionalism.
- 'A crucial opportunity to build trust' → reward preparing to add value.

Red-flag words: options that usually rank last

Refusing	Avoiding	Hiding
'You don't have capacity on this occasion'	'You'd rather others take responsibility'	'You'd prefer not to be in the spotlight'

Assuming	Comfort first	Weak effort
'If it mattered, it would be mandatory'	'You'd prefer a smaller team'	'You'll do your best' / 'you might feel unprepared'

Green-flag: energy	Green-flag: action	Green-flag: purpose
'You love / enjoy / are excited by...'	'You immediately prepare / reprioritise...'	'...so the client understands / the team succeeds'

'How do you feel?' questions

These test motivation and resilience, and they catch people out because honesty feels right. The firm wants a trainee who feels **energised by challenge and confident but grounded**. Rank like this:

Rank	Feeling	Example wording
Top	Enthusiastic + confident + focused on adding value	'You enjoy learning quickly and expect to provide interesting insights'
Middle	Willing but a bit flat, or slightly apprehensive but agrees	'Although it's not ideal, you're happy to...'
Bottom	Wants more time, expects to struggle, or declines	'You would learn better with more time, so might feel unprepared'

☺ **Is this 'faking it'?**

No. Answer as **the best, most switched-on version of yourself**: you on a good day, after a coffee, wanting the job. You'll have to live these behaviours at the assessment day and in the job, so pick the answers you're willing to grow into.

Step-by-step: answering a ranking question

06

A repeatable 6-step method

1 — Read the set-up, then the question twice
Who are you, who's asking, what's the deadline, and what has someone already told you (e.g. 'it's up to you')?

2 — Name what's being tested
Ownership? Client care? Teamwork? Learning? Adaptability? One word. This is your lens.

3 — Find the WORST option first
Look for refusing, avoiding, hiding, assuming or comfort-first. It's usually the easiest to spot. Lock it at #5.

4 — Find the BEST option
Most effective for the client and team, takes ownership, and matches the clue in the scenario. Lock it at #1.

5 — Sort the middle three
Prefer: action > asking > waiting. Prefer enthusiasm over reluctance. Penalise over-commitment and passing work on.

6 — Sanity check and move on
Would a partner be happy with your #1 and horrified by your #5? Then submit. Don't loop back for ages.

Worked example 1: ownership

Scenario: Your supervisor encourages you to think about the approach you'd like to take at the first team meeting on a big deal. Which best describes you?

1. **C.** Put thought into the approach and suggest you own several specific tasks. You enjoy accountability.
   Answers the supervisor's invitation + ownership
2. **E.** Own the tasks you're confident with; suggest others take the unfamiliar ones.
   Ownership, but limited by comfort
3. **B.** Don't mind which approach; happy to work around others.
   Flexible but passive
4. **A.** Let others own each part; you'll contribute.
   Avoids responsibility
5. **D.** Rather let others take responsibility; avoid ownership unless you have to.
   Clear red flag

The lesson: The supervisor literally asked you to think about your approach. The option that does exactly that and takes accountability wins.

Worked example 2: the 'proactive' trap

Scenario: Optional induction workshops would help you understand the firm, but your deal is getting very busy. What do you do?

1	**A.** Sign up for the workshops most beneficial to you; they add to your client-work learning. *Selective, balanced, links back to client work*
2	**B.** Can't attend, so ask for a compressed version of the materials. *Still keen to learn, respects workload*
3	**C.** Tentatively sign up in case your schedule changes. *Hedging*
4	**D.** Re-organise your diary to attend all workshops and do all client work. *Most 'proactive', but risks the client work*
5	**E.** Skip them; if they mattered they'd be mandatory. *Dismissive assumption*

The lesson: The most frantic option (D) is not the best. Judgement means doing the right amount, for the right reason.

Critical thinking (Watson Glaser style)

07

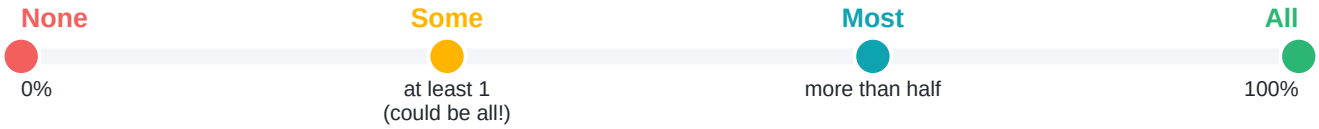
Rules that work at every firm

Macfarlanes' Stage 1 includes critical reasoning in the Watson Glaser style. The same five question types appear in almost every law firm reasoning test:

Inferences	Assumptions	Deductions	Interpretation	Arguments
How likely is this conclusion, given the facts?	Has the speaker taken this for granted?	Does this conclusion definitely follow?	Does it follow beyond reasonable doubt?	Is the argument strong or weak?

Type	Answer options	The rule to apply
Inferences	True / Probably true / Not enough data / Probably false / False (or Follows / Doesn't)	Base it only on the passage. If you need outside facts, it's 'not enough data'.
Assumptions	Assumption made / not made	Made only if the statement **can't make sense** without it.
Deductions	Follows / Does not follow	Follows only if it **must** be true. One counter-example = doesn't follow.
Interpretation	Follows / Does not follow	Follows beyond reasonable doubt, using only the passage.
Arguments	Strong / Weak	Strong = **important** AND **directly about the question**. Treat the argument as true. Changing the subject = weak.

Quantifier ladder: what the words actually prove



⚠ **Seven traps that catch most candidates**

- **Outside knowledge.** If the passage says the sky is green, the sky is green.
- **'Some' can mean all.** 'Some people prefer X' doesn't prove others don't.
- **Value judgements.** 'It is better to...' or 'you should...' almost never follows from facts.
- **Past ≠ future.** A share that fell isn't proven to keep falling.
- **Missing numbers.** If amounts aren't given, 'better off' can't be proven.
- **Plug in numbers.** For ratio puzzles, pick easy numbers (e.g. B = 4) and test each claim.
- **Draw logic puzzles.** Sketch an order line for arrival/departure puzzles before answering.

Worked example: the four shares

A is worth twice B. B is worth four times D. C and D together equal B.

Step	Working
1. Pick an easy number	Let B = 4
2. Work out the rest	A = 8, D = 1, C = 4 − 1 = 3
3. Test '10 shares in A beat 20 in B'	10 × 8 = 80, 20 × 4 = 80. Equal, so **does not follow**
4. Test 'better to buy B than C'	A value judgement about the future: **does not follow**

Stage 2: the job simulation

08

The 'day in the life' test

If you pass Stage 1, Macfarlanes sends a second online test, again with seven days to complete it. The firm describes it as an immersive 'day in the life' job simulation: you join a fictional project team and handle the kind of situations a trainee meets. Exact content changes each year, but expect:

Inbox & chats	Prioritising	Documents	Judgement calls
Emails and messages from colleagues competing for your time	Decide what to do first when everything is 'urgent'	Read short memos, notes or data and spot what matters	More ranking questions, now inside a live scenario

☰ How to prioritise in a simulation

Priority	Typical example
1. Client deadline today	Client needs a document before a meeting this afternoon
2. Partner / supervisor request with a deadline	Status report needed by end of day
3. Helping a colleague who is blocked	Colleague ill, documents still due
4. Development and admin	Optional training, internal surveys

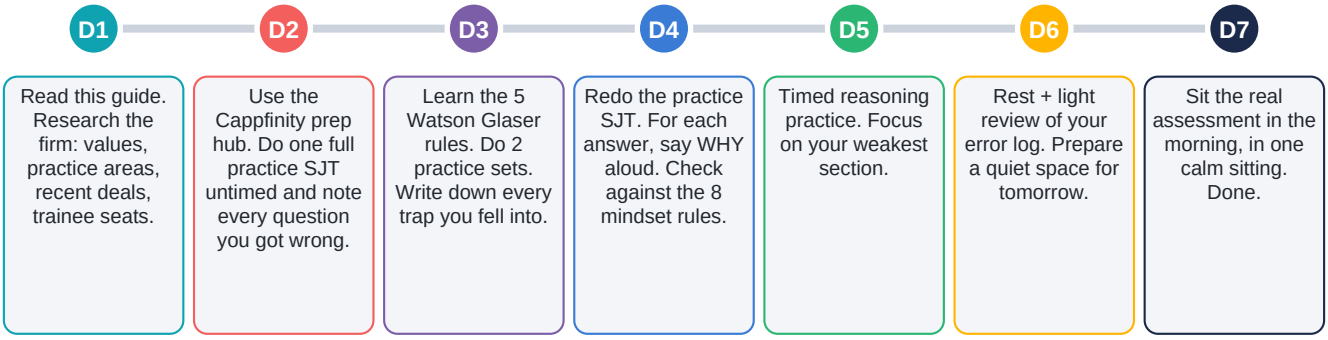
- **Same mindset as Stage 1.** Client first, ownership, flexibility, communication.
- **Accuracy matters more now.** Read every document carefully. Facts in an early email are often needed later, so **keep notes** as you go.
- **Communicate.** If you reprioritise, the best answer usually tells the affected person.

Your 7-day plan to beat the field

09

What to do before, during and after

You get seven days to complete each stage. Use the first days to prepare, and sit the test once you're ready, **not on the final evening**.



How strong candidates use practice questions

- **They study the 'why', not the answer.** Memorising rankings is useless because real questions differ. Learning the principle behind each #1 and #5 transfers.
- **They keep an error log.** One line per mistake: 'I ranked asking for help 2nd, but the supervisor had said it was up to me'. Patterns appear within a day.
- **They practise across providers.** Cappfinity, Watson Glaser and general SJTs. The same values repeat.
- **They talk to trainees.** Open days, law fairs and LinkedIn give a feel for the firm's culture, which shapes the key.

On the day: checklist

✔	Before you start
☐	Laptop charged, stable internet, notifications off, phone in another room
☐	Quiet room, 60 to 90 minutes blocked (check the firm's guidance)
☐	Pen and paper for logic puzzles and notes from the storyline
☐	Water, and you've eaten. Not the night after a big night out
☐	This guide's 5 rules (Section 1) open next to you for a 1-minute refresh

⚡ **During the test**

- Read every option before ranking. The best answer is often the last one.
- Worst first, best second, middle last.
- Commit on sliders; avoid the exact middle.
- Don't do it with friends or AI in another tab. It's often against the rules, and consistency checks expose borrowed answers. You'll also have to back it up face to face.

Quick reference: your practice set

Macfarlanes practice answers at a glance

10

Rankings from your friend's practice document, colour coded by what each question tests. Use them to check your **reasoning**, not to memorise.

ℹ **Assumption**

These rankings are a best-judgement answer key built from the principles in this guide. They are **not** an official Macfarlanes or Cappfinity key, which is never published. The first and last choices are the most reliable; the middle three are closer calls.

Q	Seat	Topic	Ranking (best → worst)	Tests
1	Corporate	Relationships with new colleagues	**C, A, D, E, B**	**Teamwork**
2	Corporate	Steep learning curve	**E, B, A, C, D**	**Learning**
3	Corporate	Ownership at the team meeting	**C, E, B, A, D**	**Ownership**
4	Corporate	Optional workshops	**A, B, C, D, E**	**Learning**
5	Banking	Approaching the client meeting	**A, B, E, C, D**	**Client**
6	Banking	Explaining complex content	**C, B, D, E, A**	**Client**
7	Banking	Covering an ill colleague	**D, C, B, A, E**	**Flexibility**
8	Private Client	Stuck, supervisor on holiday	**D, E, A, B, C**	**Resourceful**
9	Private Client	Lynette asks you to do the analysis	**A, B, C, E, D**	**Ownership**

Q	Seat	Topic	Ranking (best → worst)	Tests
10	Private Client	Presenting to a formal client	**E, A, D, C, B**	Confidence
11	Private Client	Tax treaty research + lead meeting	**A, C, E, B, D**	Learning
12	Litigation	Research approach	**E, B, A, D, C**	Independence
13	Litigation	Agenda changes on the day	**E, C, D, B, A**	Flexibility
14	Litigation	Simplifying a document	**B, E, A, C, D**	Client
15	Litigation	Types of tasks to try	**A, B, C, D, E**	Learning

Set	Topic	Answers (in order on screen)
1	Company strategy	Doesn't follow, Follows, Follows, Doesn't follow
2	Four couriers	Doesn't follow, Follows, Follows, Follows
3	Four shares	Doesn't follow, Follows, Doesn't follow, Doesn't follow
4	AI predictions	Doesn't follow, Doesn't follow, Doesn't follow, Follows (moderate confidence)
5	Jo's conference	Not assumed, Assumed, Assumed, Not assumed
6	Admin tasks	Strong, Strong (moderate confidence), Weak, Strong

Assumptions, glossary and sources

11

The small print, in plain English

Assumptions this guide makes

- You are applying to UK law firms for a vacation scheme or training contract (2027 cycle).
- Macfarlanes' process is as described on its careers pages in 2026: online application, Stage 1 SJT + critical reasoning, Stage 2 job simulation, assessment day. It may change.
- Exact scoring methods are not published by firms or Cappfinity. Where this guide describes scoring, it's based on widely reported candidate and provider information, and labelled.
- Firm-to-provider pairings come from candidate forums and change often.
- The practice rankings are best-judgement, not an official answer key.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
SJT	Situational Judgement Test: realistic work scenarios where you choose or rank responses
Watson Glaser	The best-known critical thinking test, published by Pearson TalentLens
Cappfinity	Assessment company that builds Macfarlanes' online tests
Vacation scheme	Paid 1 to 3 week work placement; often the main route to a training contract
Training contract	Two-year paid training job leading to qualification as a solicitor

Term	Meaning
Seat	A 4 to 6 month rotation in one practice area (e.g. Litigation) during training
Supervisor	The lawyer (often a senior associate) who oversees your work in a seat
Associate / Partner	Qualified lawyer / senior lawyer who co-owns the firm
Due diligence	Investigating a company before a deal, to find risks
Norm group	The comparison group your score is measured against
Assessment day	Final in-person stage: interviews, case study, group and written exercises
SQE	Solicitors Qualifying Exam, the current route to qualifying as a solicitor

Sources

- Macfarlanes: Training Programme
- Macfarlanes: Assessment process
- AllAboutLaw: Macfarlanes application process
- The Lawyer Portal: Watson Glaser test
- Legal Cheek: How to nail Watson Glaser tests (2026)
- The Corporate Law Academy: 2025-26 applications thread
- Intervyo: How Cappfinity assessments are scored (prep provider)

♥ Final word

Thousands of people sit this test. The ones who pass aren't the ones who memorise answers. They're the ones who can picture themselves as a trainee who **puts the client first, says yes and makes it work, owns their tasks, and loves learning**, and who read every question carefully enough to spot what it's really asking. That's a skill you can practise. Good luck.